PRESIDENCY DESK · BRIEF 3 OF 4

Maritime Surveillance

Cooperation

Ireland's 880,000 km² of Atlantic EEZ and critical subsea cable infrastructure give it an irreplaceable geographic position in European maritime security. The Presidency is the window to convert that geography into a permanent, funded role — or to leave it as Europe's blind spot.

Security Ireland

June 2026

KEY FINDINGS

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Ireland's maritime domain is one of Europe's largest and least monitored. Over 20 subsea cables make landfall on Irish shores, carrying approximately 90% of transatlantic data traffic. Ireland joined CISE in April 2025, the EUMSS progress report falls due during Ireland's Presidency in October 2026, and the EU Cable Action Plan is being implemented now. Four EU frameworks are being shaped during Ireland's term. If Ireland uses its chair to embed Atlantic maritime surveillance as a named priority in these frameworks, its geographic position becomes a permanent European security asset. If it chairs passively, others define the architecture and Ireland's 880,000 km² remains a gap, not a contribution.

The strategic objective

Ireland's strategic objective for the Presidency is to establish itself as a permanent, credible contributor to European security in the domains where its geography is irreplaceable — maritime surveillance, subsea infrastructure protection, and cyber resilience — so that when the Presidency ends in December 2026, Ireland has locked in a role that outlasts the political window.

This is not altruism. A permanent role means Ireland is no longer vulnerable to the free-rider accusation. It means EU funding instruments recognise Ireland's contribution. The Presidency is the six-month window in which this can be achieved.

WHY MARITIME SURVEILLANCE MATTERS FOR THIS OBJECTIVE

Maritime surveillance is the domain where Ireland's geographic contribution is most visible and least deniable. Ireland's EEZ covers 880,000 km² of the northeast Atlantic. Its shores are the western terminus of the transatlantic cable network. This geography is irreplaceable — no other EU member state occupies this position. But geography alone is not a contribution. Ireland must demonstrate it can monitor, share data about, and help protect this domain. The EU frameworks being shaped during Ireland's Presidency are the mechanism through which this capability is either built and funded — or not.

Ireland's maritime domain

Ireland's maritime domain

880,000 km² of Atlantic EEZ — one of Europe's largest, and least monitored

880,000	20+	90%	9	0
km² EEZ	subsea cable landings	transatlantic data	naval vessels	primary radar

THE CREDIBILITY GAP

Domain	Ireland's capability	Consequence
Surface surveillance	No primary radar; AIS only	Cannot detect non-cooperative vessels
Subsea monitoring	No capability	Cables unmonitored; relies on operators
Anti-submarine warfare	No sonar, no ASW aircraft	UK provides de facto umbrella

Source: Commission on the Defence Forces (2022); Department of Defence Annual Report 2024; Naval Service operational data.

Figure 1: Ireland's maritime domain. 880,000 km² of Atlantic EEZ, over 20 subsea cable landings, 9 naval vessels, no primary radar, no subsea monitoring capability. The credibility gap between Ireland's geographic responsibility and its operational capacity is the largest in Europe.

Ireland's Exclusive Economic Zone covers approximately 880,000 square kilometres of the northeast Atlantic: one of the largest in Europe. This zone encompasses shipping lanes critical to European trade and waters where Russian submarine activity has increased since 2014. Over twenty major subsea cables make landfall on Irish shores, carrying the vast majority of transatlantic data traffic; the Celtic Interconnector to France is expected by 2027; the Far North Fiber linking Ireland, Alaska, Japan, and Norway is planned for 2026.

Yet Ireland's capacity to monitor this domain is near zero. The Naval Service operates nine vessels, several approaching end of life. Ireland has no primary radar — the programme targets 2028. It has no anti-submarine warfare capability, just as it has no subsea monitoring capability. The UK Royal Navy provides the de facto maritime security umbrella with no treaty basis, no formal governance, and no accountability mechanism.

The EU frameworks being shaped

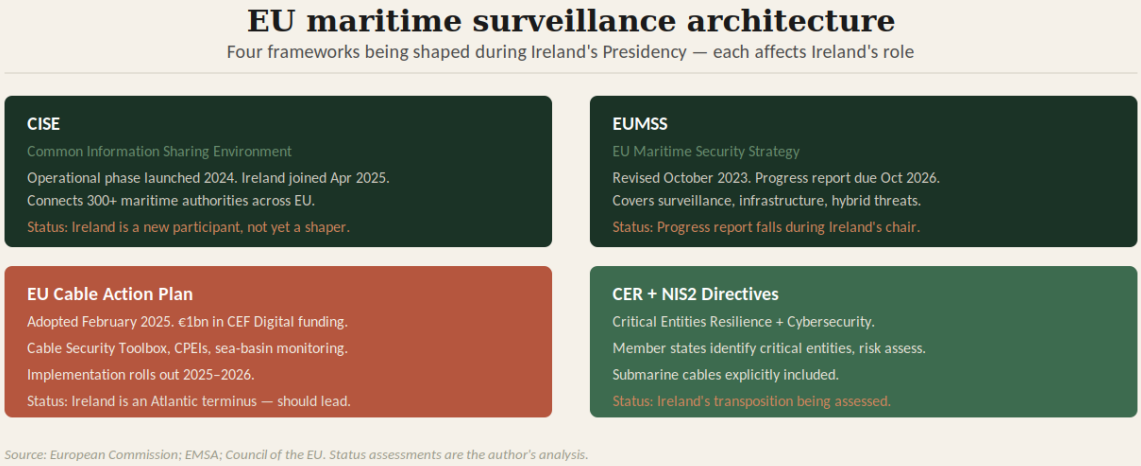


Figure 2: EU maritime surveillance architecture. Four frameworks being shaped during Ireland's Presidency: CISE (operational phase), the EUMSS (progress report due October 2026), the EU Cable Action Plan (implementation 2025–2026), and the CER/NIS2 Directives (critical entity identification).

Four EU frameworks govern maritime surveillance and subsea infrastructure protection. All four are being shaped during Ireland's Presidency term.

CISE — the Common Information Sharing Environment — is a network connecting European maritime surveillance systems to enable cross-border, cross-sector data exchange. Ireland's Defence Forces joined CISE in April 2025. The operational phase, managed by EMSA, was launched in 2024. The classified network is expected operational from late 2025. Ireland is currently a new participant, not yet a shaper.

The EU Maritime Security Strategy was revised in October 2023. A joint progress report from the Commission and High Representative is due to the Council by October 2026 — during Ireland's chair. The report will assess progress on surveillance, infrastructure protection, and hybrid threat response. Ireland chairs the Council reception of this report.

The EU Cable Action Plan was adopted in February 2025. It commits €1 billion in CEF Digital funding for submarine cable security. It calls for sea-basin monitoring, Cable Projects of European Interest, and a Cable Security Toolbox. Implementation runs through 2025–2026. Ireland, as the Atlantic terminus of the transatlantic cable network, should be leading the Atlantic basin response.

What's being decided during Ireland's term

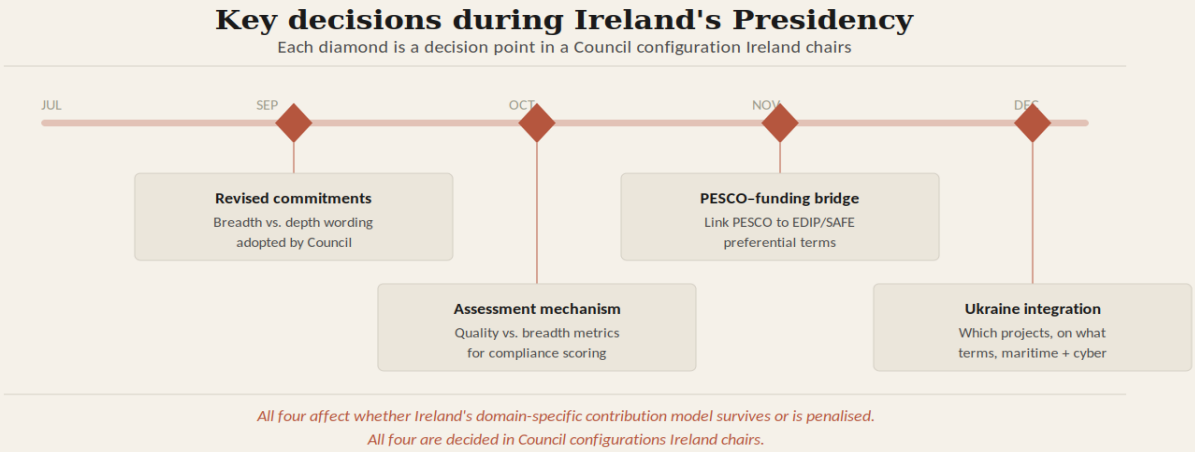


Figure 3: Key decisions during Ireland's Presidency term (July–December 2026). Four maritime surveillance decisions Ireland chairs. All determine whether Ireland's Atlantic geography becomes a permanent, funded European security asset.

1. CISE Atlantic node designation

CISE operates through decentralised nodes. Ireland should propose hosting the Atlantic maritime data hub — fusing national Naval Service data, bilateral UK–Ireland intelligence, and EU satellite imagery into a single Atlantic awareness picture. This makes Ireland a data provider, not just a consumer.

2. EUMSS progress report and Council conclusions

The three-year progress report on the EU Maritime Security Strategy is due in October 2026. Ireland chairs the Council that receives it. The Council conclusions Ireland drafts can name Atlantic surveillance and subsea infrastructure protection as priority areas requiring additional investment and coordination.

3. Cable Projects of European Interest

The Cable Action Plan calls for a priority list of Cable Projects of European Interest. Ireland's Atlantic cable routes — including the Far North Fiber and Celtic Interconnector — should be designated as CPEIs, qualifying for CEF Digital funding and enhanced protection requirements.

4. MFF maritime surveillance chapter

Ireland is expected to advance the next seven-year EU budget by Christmas 2026. Maritime surveillance should be named as a priority domain in the MFF framework text, alongside subsea infrastructure protection. This gives Ireland's geographic contribution a permanent funding line.

Ireland as Atlantic cable terminus

Over 20 subsea cable landings — carrying 90% of EU–US data traffic

KEY ATLANTIC CABLES VIA IRELAND

Cable system	Route
AEConnect / Havfrue	Ireland – US / Denmark
CELTIC / Hibernia Atlantic	Ireland – Canada / US
MARE / Google	Ireland – US
Celtic Interconnector	Ireland – France (energy, 2027)
Far North Fiber	Ireland – Alaska – Japan – Norway
ESAT / GTT	Ireland – UK (multiple)

Why this matters for the thesis

Ireland is not just adjacent to subsea infrastructure. It is the western terminus of the transatlantic cable network. This geography is irreplaceable.

The EU Cable Action Plan invests €1 billion in cable security. If Ireland hosts the Atlantic monitoring node, its geographic position is permanently funded.

Trend: Ireland is becoming more critical, not less.
Celtic Interconnector (2027), Far North Fiber (2026), and hyperscaler data centre expansion are increasing Ireland's node centrality.

Source: TeleGeography submarine cable database; EirGrid; Commission on the Defence Forces report (2022).

Figure 4: Ireland as Atlantic cable terminus. Over 20 subsea cable landings carrying 90% of EU–US data traffic. Ireland is becoming a more critical node, not a less critical one. The EU Cable Action Plan invests €1 billion — Ireland should host the Atlantic monitoring node.

What Ireland should do

Four actions, each justified by how it advances the strategic objective of locking in Ireland's permanent maritime security role.

1. Propose hosting the Atlantic CISE node

Ireland should propose that its CISE integration includes hosting the Atlantic sea-basin surveillance node. This makes Ireland the data hub for the northeast Atlantic — fusing Naval Service tracking, Sea-Scan maritime AI, bilateral UK intelligence, and EU satellite imagery into a single operational picture. The node should be located at the National Maritime Coordination Centre.

> **THIS LOCKS IN:** *Ireland as the Atlantic maritime data hub. A CISE node that provides data is a permanent infrastructure role. A node that only consumes data is a client relationship that can be redirected.*

2. Ensure Atlantic cable routes are designated as CPEIs

Ireland should ensure that its transatlantic cable routes are included on the Cable Projects of European Interest list. CPEI designation qualifies routes for CEF Digital funding, enhanced protection requirements, and priority in the Cable Security Toolbox. Ireland's geographic position as the Atlantic terminus makes this designation self-evident — but only if Ireland requests it.

> **THIS LOCKS IN:** *Ireland's cable infrastructure as a named EU strategic asset. CPEI designation brings funding, protection standards, and permanent institutional recognition of Ireland's critical position.*

3. Shape the EUMSS progress report Council conclusions

Ireland chairs the Council that receives the EUMSS progress report in October 2026. The Council conclusions Ireland drafts should name Atlantic maritime surveillance and subsea infrastructure protection as priority areas. This is not special pleading — these domains serve European interests. But if the conclusions focus on the Mediterranean and Baltic (where other Presidencies have steered attention), the Atlantic falls off the EU maritime security agenda.

> **THIS LOCKS IN:** *Atlantic maritime surveillance as a named priority in EU maritime security policy. Council conclusions persist as the reference text for future action.*

4. Embed maritime surveillance in the MFF framework text

The defence and security chapter of the next MFF should include maritime surveillance and subsea infrastructure protection as named priority domains. Ireland should draft the framework text. If the MFF is written generically, funding flows to air defence and ground forces. If maritime surveillance is named, Ireland's geographic contribution has a permanent funding pathway.

> **THIS LOCKS IN:** *Ireland's maritime geography as a permanent category in the EU budget. Survives beyond any single programme or Presidency.*

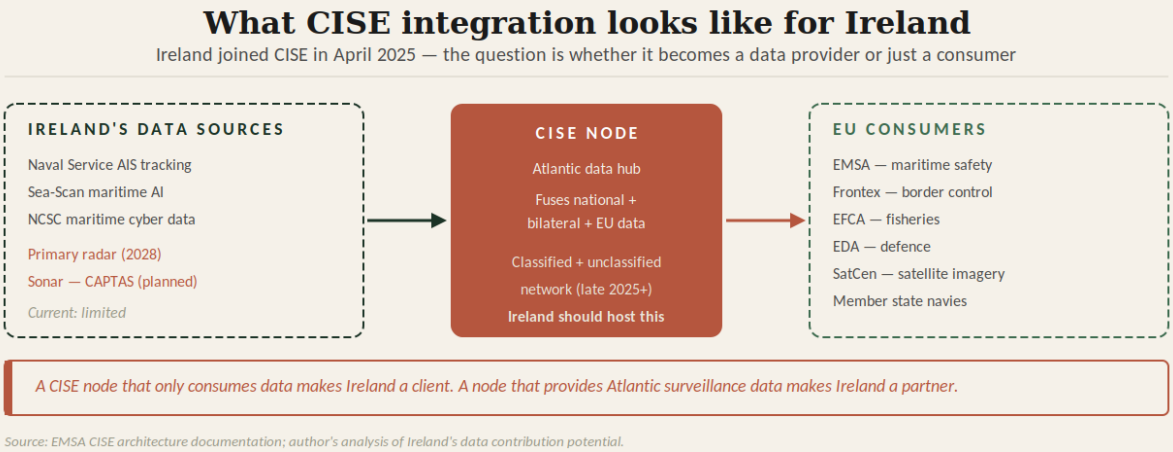
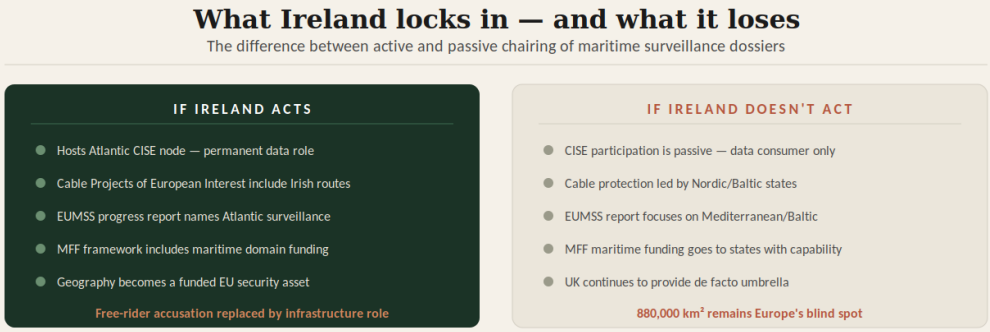


Figure 5: What CISE integration looks like for Ireland. Ireland's data sources feed into a CISE Atlantic node, which serves EU agencies and member state navies. The question is whether Ireland becomes a data provider (permanent role) or just a consumer (dispensable).

What happens if Ireland doesn't act

If Ireland chairs these meetings passively, the maritime surveillance architecture is shaped by others. CISE's Atlantic coverage depends on data Ireland does not provide. The Cable Action Plan's Atlantic basin monitoring is led by Nordic states. The EUMSS progress report focuses on the Mediterranean and Baltic. The MFF maritime chapter funds capability domains where Ireland has nothing to offer.

Ireland's 880,000 km² remains the largest unmonitored EEZ in Europe. The UK continues to provide the de facto maritime umbrella. Ireland's geographic assets remain a vulnerability, not a contribution. The free-rider accusation is not just about spending — it is about a state that sits on irreplaceable maritime geography and does nothing with it.



Source: Author's analysis.

Figure 6: What Ireland locks in through active chairing — and what it loses through passive chairing. The difference is whether 880,000 km² of Atlantic EEZ becomes a funded European security asset or remains Europe's blind spot.

THE BOTTOM LINE

Ireland's maritime geography is irreplaceable. No other EU member state occupies the Atlantic position Ireland holds. But geography alone is not a contribution — it is an asset only if Ireland demonstrates it can monitor, share data about, and help protect its domain. The Presidency is the window to convert geographic position into institutional position. After December 2026, the architecture is set and the political attention moves elsewhere.

Recommendations

#	Action	What it locks in	For whom	By when
1	Propose hosting the Atlantic CISE maritime data node at the National Maritime Coordination Centre	Ireland as Atlantic maritime data hub — permanent infrastructure role	DFA / Dept of Defence / EMSA liaison	September 2026
2	Ensure Ireland's transatlantic cable routes are designated Cable Projects of European Interest	Ireland's cable infrastructure as named EU strategic asset	DECC / DFA / Cable Expert Group	October 2026
3	Draft EUMSS progress report Council conclusions naming Atlantic surveillance as priority	Atlantic maritime surveillance in EU maritime security policy	DFA Presidency team / EEAS	October 2026
4	Embed maritime surveillance and subsea protection as named domains in MFF framework text	Ireland's maritime geography as permanent EU budget category	General Affairs Council / European Council prep	December 2026

A NOTE ON METHOD

This brief assesses EU maritime surveillance frameworks through the lens of Ireland's strategic objective: locking in a permanent security role in its geographic domains. It does not assess the technical adequacy of Ireland's Naval Service or the operational merits of specific surveillance systems. Those questions are addressed in the companion Ireland's Defence Problem paper. This brief asks: given the EU frameworks being shaped, what should Ireland do to ensure its maritime geography is recognised as a contribution?

Series context Series context

Third in the Presidency Desk series — four briefs on the EU instruments Ireland must steer during its Council Presidency. Companion briefs: ReArm Europe; Maritime Surveillance Cooperation; Hybrid Threats and Cyber Defence.

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